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MEMORANDUM

DATE October 14, 2025
TO Portland Public Schools Board of Education
FROM Michelle Morrison, Chief Financial Officer
CC Dr. Kimberlee Armstrong
SUBJECT Outdoor School Cost Analysis

During the 2025 legislative session, the state appropriated support for Outdoor School was reduced by 20% in order to maintain funding in other areas after a negative June state revenue forecast. As a result, the five day program offered by Multnomah Education Service District (MESD) to all 6th graders in Portland Public Schools will be reduced to four days in the 2025-26 school year.

At the September 9th Board Meeting, the Directors requested an Outdoor School Cost Analysis that compares the scope and cost of Outdoor School prior and post legislated funding. Staff collaborated with MESD representatives to explore the current state, program options, and to review these costs before and after Measure 99[1] was passed in 2016. Reimbursement for Outdoor School first occurred in 2017-28 and the grant has been fully funded since that time with Oregon State University Extension as the administrator.

Please see the cost comparison and funding sources below and notes for Outdoor School in PPS.

Full Week MESD Outdoor School Program	**2016-17**	**2024-25**	**Projected 2024-25 3% Annual CPI**
Actual Attendance	3,507	2,884	2,884
MESD Program Costs*	$1,529,403	$3,372,438	$1,896,460
Pass-through reimbursement to PPS	$0	-$390,153	-$390,153
Metro Credits	-$240,320	$0	$0
ECSWC Credits **	-$94,220	$0	$0
Total	**$1,194,863**	**$2,982,285**	**$1,506,307**
Per Student Cost	**$341**	**$1,034**	**$522**
* MESD program cost is net of available program-wide credits: NSLP, MAC, Metro admin, etc.			
** ECSWC Credits ended 2016-17, no Metro funding after 2017-18 year.			

[1] Measure 99 earmarked 4.0% of state lottery revenues to qualifying Outdoor School Programs.

Costs for Outdoor School have expanded beyond a 3.0% annual average consumer price index due to program expansion. Please see this memo from MESD regarding Outdoor School investments since 2016-17.

Linked MESD Memo

Portland Public Schools Program Investments Since 2016–2017

Since the passage of Measure 99, MESD has made significant investments to strengthen Outdoor School for students. These changes have improved quality, equity, and access—but they have also increased program costs compared to 2016–2017.

Professionalized Staffing

- **Before Measure 99:** The program was staffed primarily by short-term, seasonal employees.
- **After Measure 99:** Half of our instructor team now works extended calendars, with benefits and added days dedicated to supporting schools.
    - This shift has doubled staff retention and ensures consistency in student experience.

Expanded Student & Family Support

- Staff attend back-to-school nights, conferences, science nights, and family information sessions to strengthen engagement.
- Multiple classroom visits are offered before Outdoor School to build rapport and support attendance.
- A Gear Library provides coats, sleeping bags, boots, clothing, and hygiene supplies free of charge. Families can access the library weekly with staff and translation support, or request gear delivered to schools.
- Day programming is now available for students unable to stay overnight, requiring additional staff at each site.

Increased High School Engagement

- Staff visit high school classes and host tabling events to recruit high school Student Leader volunteers.
- Off-season and weekend programming introduces high school students to career pathways in science, education, and natural resources.

Cost Drivers

- Rising CBA (collective bargaining agreement) obligations, payroll, and benefit costs have increased salaries.
- Rental/lease costs increased after Measure 99, as programs were encouraged to move from subsidized rates to actual market costs to ensure the long-term sustainability of sites.

Why Costs Are Higher Today

Together, these investments mean that Outdoor School is no longer a short-term, seasonal program—it is a comprehensive, year-round system that supports students, families, and schools. While program costs are higher, so is the value delivered to PPS students.